BROOKBANKS

1335 Swindon NEV

Thornhill Road Access
Walking, Cycling and Horse-Riding Assessment Review
11th January 2024
Ref: 1335WCHARRV4

1 Introduction

1.1 Brookbanks is appointed by Swindon Eastern Villages Consortium to provide transport and highways advice to support the development of a proposed development site to the north east of Swindon and in particular the proposed site access from Thornhill Road.

1.2 This note forms the walking, cycling and Horse-Riding Assessment for the proposed junction and has been prepared support the following:

- Discharge of the Condition 26 Thornhill Road Junction which states the following
- *Notwithstanding the submitted details, prior to the occupation of any dwelling, detailed design of access proposals in broad compliance with drawing number 1335/HL/56 F (submitted to LPA on 13th October 2017), for the development onto Thornhill Road will be submitted to and approved in writing by the Local Planning Authority. The access proposals will be supported by Stage 2 Road Safety Audit and Walking, Cycling and Horse Riding Assessment and Review and will directly consider the vehicle and pedestrian access requirements of adjacent properties, including turning of vehicles and road crossing, through both construction phase and operational phase. The access proposals will be completed in all respects prior to the occupation of the 300 dwelling, in accordance with the approved plans and maintained as such thereafter to serve the development.*
- S278 Technical Approval

1.3 The purpose of this WCHAR note is to:

- Facilitate the inclusion of walking, cycling and horse-riding modes of travel in the highway scheme design process from the earliest stage
- Identify any constraints on existing provisions from the proposed highway scheme
- Identify opportunities for improved facilities and integration with the local and national networks
- Demonstrates effective discussions with the local highway authority including consideration of vehicular and pedestrian access requirements of adjacent properties.

1.4 The WCHAR process is made up of two distinct parts. The first part is an assessment of the existing situation, the Walking, Cycling & Horse-Riding Assessment, or Assessment Report. The second part relates to an ongoing review of user opportunities throughout the design process, the Walking, Cycling & Horse-Riding Review, or Review Report. The WCHAR process concludes prior to the commencement of construction of a highway scheme.

1.5 This Assessment Report has been produced in accordance with the requirements set out in DMRB GG 142 Walking, Cycling and Horse-Riding Assessment and Review (WCHAR) as part of the proposed site access on Thornhill Road.

1.6 The scale of the proposed scheme has been assessed and is considered to be a small highway scheme based on the advice provided within DMRB GG142, Section 2.

Site Information

1.7 The site location and boundary is shown in **Figure 1-1**.

Figure 1-1: Development Site and Boundary

1.8 The highway proposal is to provide a new roundabout on Thornhill Road to provide access to the proposed site. The development comprises of two parts, being the growth to the south of South Marston and to the

east, a development of a new neighbouring community at Rowborough.

1.9 The proposed highway scheme will see the construction of a three-arm roundabout as shown in Appendix A that will provide access to the proposed development from Thornhill Road to the southwest of the development site, as approved as part of the outline decision notice S/OUT/13/1555. This roundabout will reduce speeds, resulting in a betterment to Priory Lodge.

1.10 The roundabout will include a traffic island on the southern arm of Thornhill roundabout which will facilitate pedestrian connectivity from the footway on the southern side of the primary street towards the bridleway on the western side of Thornhill Road providing onwards connections to Keypoint roundabout, retail park and Eastern Flyer into Swindon.

1.11 Cycling routes are designed to provided connectivity across the A420, via the green bridge, and eastwards along Morses Lane.

1.12 The existing Public Right of Way (PRoW) network as shown in Appendix B will not be affected by the proposed highway scheme.

Study Area

1.13 The study area for the assessment includes the proposed site access on Thornhill Road along with the existing walking, cycleway and horse-riding network currently in place which may be affected by the proposed roundabout scheme. This includes the existing PRoW running adjacent to the west of Thornhill Road. The study area is shown within the red line in **Figure 1-2** below:

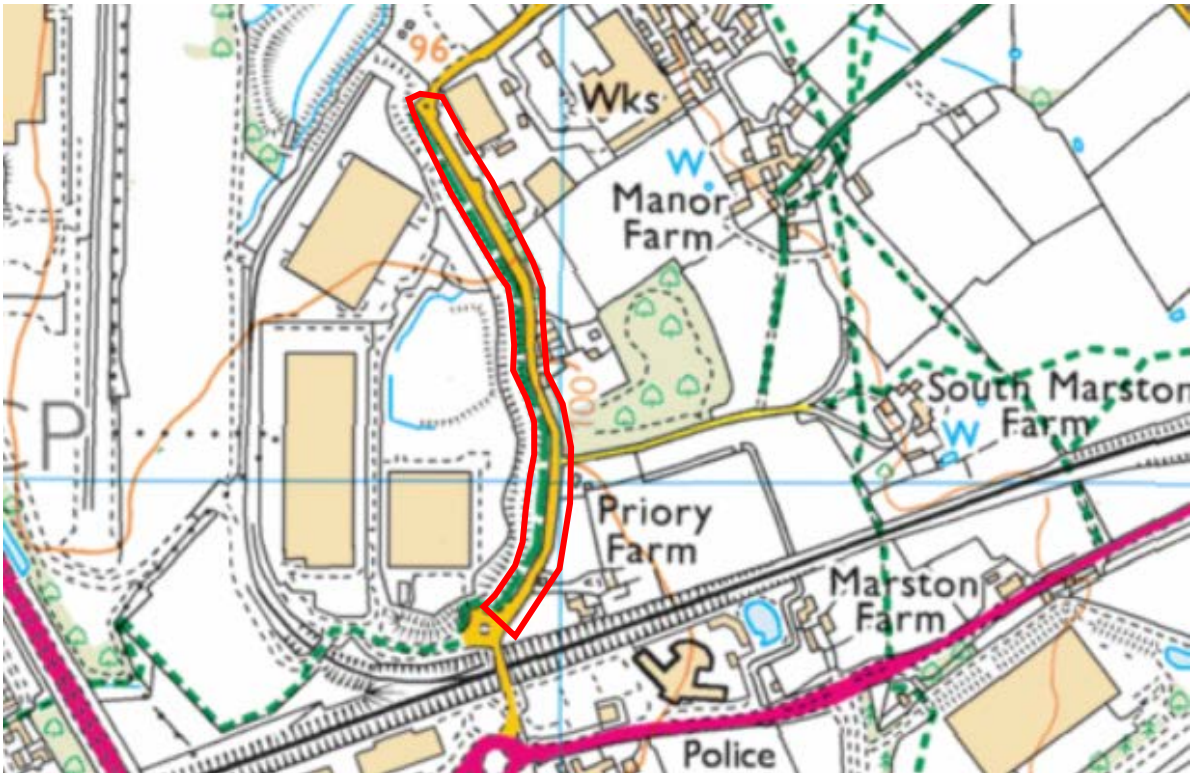


Figure 1-2: WCHAR Study Area

2 WCHAR Assessment

Policies and Strategies

2.1 The policies and strategies which have been reviewed as part of this assessment are shown below:

- Swindon Green Infrastructure Strategy for Swindon 2010-2026
- Swindon Local Transport Plan (LTP) 2011-2026

2.2 Both documents mentioned above include Swindon Borough Council's proposals for transport provision in the county, including walking, cycling and horse riding.

2.3 Under Policy 2.12 – 2.16 of the LTP titled 'Alignment with local strategies' states the objectives for highway developments including provisions for walking and cycling, with the strategy including:

- Theme 3 – Concerning the safeguarding of the environment for future generations, including access to fast and frequent transport, as well as a safe and good quality network for walking and cycling
- 2.16: The LTP sets out connections between wider local authorities and the policies and programmes set out in the plan, along with indicators and targets to demonstrate successful delivery

2.4 The Green Infrastructure Strategy also highlights the ambition to improve the sustainability and quality of life in relation to transport. Policy 3.1 states that 'The demands and needs of particular users e.g. people with disabilities, cyclists and horse riders need to be better understood and incorporated into future strategy'. This is to be achieved by incorporation of local transport plans, right of way improvement plans, parks and open spaces/leisure strategies.

2.5 The Rights of Way Improvement Plan sets out the provision to enhance the local walking and cycling routes. It is sets out to do this by planning to identify opportunities to improve access to the countryside. This will be done by providing alternatives to car related leisure activities. As a result, this will reduce congestion on rural roads and desired visitor destinations. It will also potentially better air quality and active travel which looks to improve health.

Collision Data

2.6 Data from online resource Crashmap has been analysed for the years of 2019-2020. It has shown there to be no accidents on Thornhill Road specifically, however it has been recorded that one slight collision occurred on Old Vicarage Lane. There were also 17 collisions on the A420 from White Hart roundabout until the A420 Shell Garage.

2.7 It is also to be noted that within a 5 year period from 2016-2020, there has been no incidents related to pedestrians and cyclists. The same 5 year period shows 3 incidents on Thornhill Road in particular.

Existing Pedestrian Facilities

2.8 There is an existing PRoW which is circa 2.5m wide located to the west of Thornhill Road which runs adjacent to the road from North to South. The PRoW is shown in **Figure 2-1** below:

Figure 2-1: Existing PRoW

2.9 The termination point to the north of the PRoW forms a crossing point to an existing footway which spans circa 85m north before termination. The pedestrian provision on the Thornhill Road study area then finishes with the highway being the only method for pedestrian travel further north of Thornhill Road. The crossing point for the existing PRoW is shown below in **Figure 2-2**:

Figure 2-2: Existing PRoW Crossing Point

2.10 The existing footway connection offers a pedestrian route along Thornhill Road temporarily before termination. After this there is no pedestrian access until the Ash Gardens Junction, where there is a footway provision on one side of the highway. The existing footway connection to the crossing is shown in **Figure 2-3** below:

Figure 2-3: Existing Footway Connection to crossing point

2.11 The termination of the existing footway connection is shown in **Figure 2-4** below:

Figure 2-4: Existing Footway termination point

2.12 The existing PRoW and pedestrian routes are shown below in **Figure 2-5**:

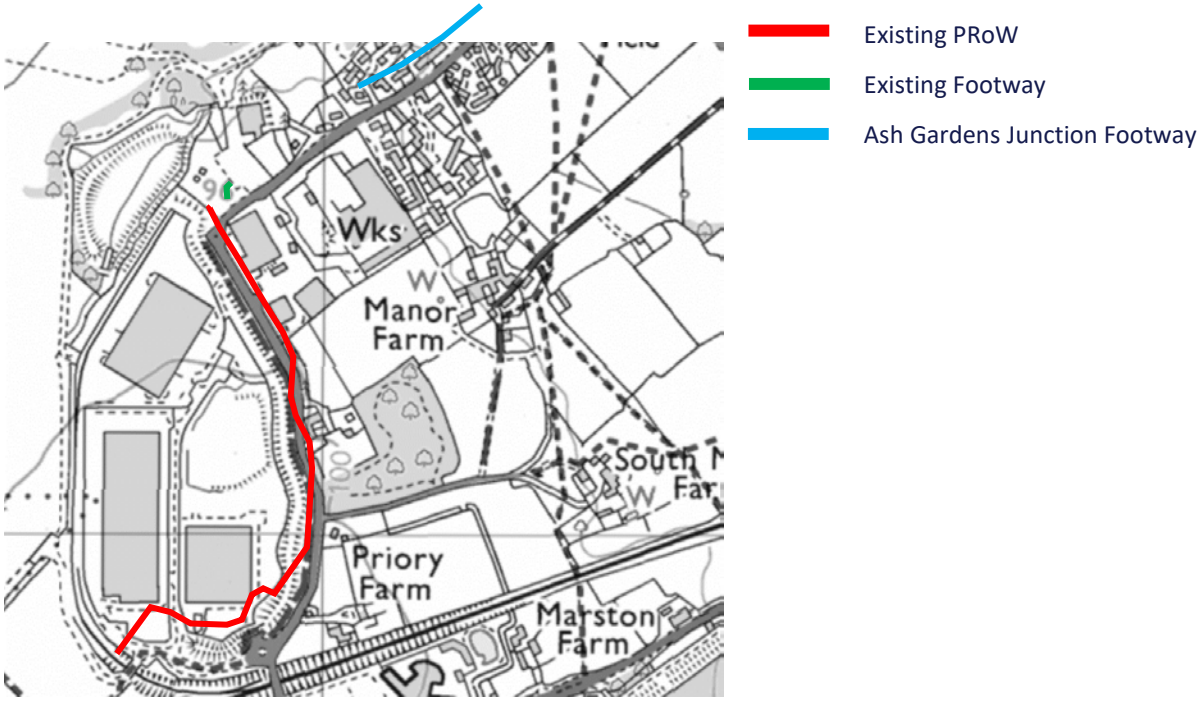


Figure 2-5: PRoW and Pedestrian Route on Thornhill Road near Access Point

Existing Cycle Facilities

2.13 An extract from the Swindon Cycle map as shown below in **Figure 2-6**, shows there is an existing cycleway route which is the same route as the PRoW running adjacent to Thornhill Road. The map also indicates recommended cycle route (on-road) along with toucan crossing points.

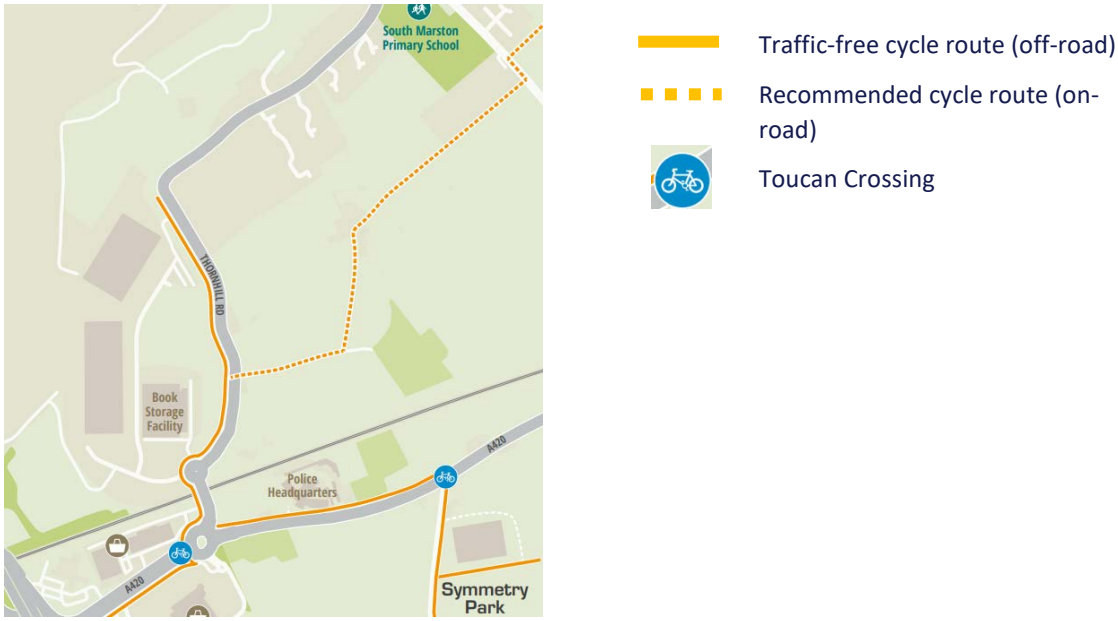


Figure 2-6: Swindon Cycle Map extract

2.14 The cycle routes provided are both traffic free and on-road alternatives which provide access to Nightingale Wood located north east of Thornhill Road, where there are multiple cycle route tracks.

Existing Equestrian Facilities

2.15 Appendix B shows there to be a dedicated bridleway running adjacent to Thornhill Road. This path runs adjacent to the PRoW forementioned. Upon termination point of both PRoW and bridleway, the crossing point as mentioned above provides pedestrian access, however there is no further dedicated equestrian provision. Further along Thornhill Road there is a traffic calming measure which has access on the opposite side of the island in comparison with the road, which has the potential to allow for cyclists and horse-riders to pass through. This is shown in **Figure 2-7** below:

Figure 2-7: Thornhill Road traffic calming measure

Existing Bus Services

2.16 The nearest bus stops to the site are located south of Thornhill Road at Gablecross and adjacent to the Sainsbury's. The Sainsbury's bus stop is approximately 350m south of the Thornhill Road Site Access and operates the 23, S6, M34, and M38. The Gablecross bus stop only operates the M34. Both stop have seating and shelter.

2.17 Details for the busses and coaches, taken from swindonbus.com, stagecoachbus.com, uk.megabus.com and bustimes.org are summarised in below in **Table 2-1:**

Service / Operator	Destination	Frequency
23 – Swindon's Bus Company	Stratton Park, Swindon – Fleming Way, Swindon	Mondays to Saturdays: 10:16, 12:16 , 14:16
S6 Gold – Stagecoach West	Swindon – Oxford	Monday to Saturday: every 15 minutes, as well as running hourly in the evenings. Sundays: hourly
M34 – Megabus Coach Service	Newcastle upon Tyne – Cardiff	Friday – Sunday : Once a day at 8:30
M38 – Megabus Coach Service	Cabot Circus – Bradford City Centre	Friday – Sunday : Once a day at 22:15

Table 2-1: Bus Routes nearest to site

Existing Rail Services

2.18 Swindon Railway station is located approximately 3.5 miles southwest to the Thornhill Access point. There are available cycle parkin stands/racks on site. The S6 bus route stops at Swindon Bus Station which is approx. 4 minute walk away from Swindon Railway Station.

2.19 The station is managed by Great Western Railway and provides daily services to London and Birmingham frequently. The station offers the following facilities:

- 197 cycle parking spaces
- 591 car parking spaces
- Ticket office
- Ticket machines
- Step free access
- Toilets

- Post box
- Retail Outlet
- Cycle hire

Trip Generators

2.20 Trip generation for the proposed development has been highlighted in the Transport Assessment carried out for the whole site which is referenced 1335-1/TA/01.

2.21 The trip generation has been agreed between Brookbanks and representatives of SBC / HE by way of a Technical Note reference 203064. The following tables summarise the agreed development trips:

Trips	Morning Peak		Evening Peak	
	IN	OUT	IN	OUT
Phase I trips	226	788	833	477

Figure 2-8: Trip Generation – Phase I

Trips	Morning Peak		Evening Peak	
	IN	OUT	IN	OUT
Phase I trips	460	189	157	415

Figure 2-9: Trip Generation – Phase IA

Trips	Morning Peak		Evening Peak	
	IN	OUT	IN	OUT
Phase I trips	281	1534	1678	898

Figure 2-10: Trip Generation – Phase II

Site Visit

2.22 Throughout the lifetime of the project, numerous site visits have been carried out to gain an understanding of the site environment. In additional to these, specific site visits for the audit team were arranged to consider the specific criteria relating to the WCHAR assessment. The date for the WCHAR specific site visit was 10th January 2022 – 10:00 to 15:00.

2.23 The site visit was undertaken by the lead assessor to gain an appreciation of existing usage. The site visit was undertaken during daylight hours and the weather was fine and dry. The routes included Thornhill Road and Old Vicarage Lane, the PRoW and bridleway were observed.

2.24 The key findings from the site visit were that the bridleway and PRoW would remain as exiting and would not be affected by the Thornhill Road Access Roundabout. It was observed that horse riders were using the access route at the traffic calming measure on Thornhill Road as mentioned above in paragraph 2.15.

2.25 The PRoW and bridleway were seen being used, and both routes appeared to be worn which is an indication of usage.

Consultation with Key Stakeholders and Wider Public

2.26 The proposed junction forms part of the approved planning application S/OUT/13/1555. Contact with representatives of key stakeholders to understand any local issues pertinent to walking, cycling and horse-riding was carried out as part of the consultation process on the full application. A record of liaison with key stakeholders can be found within the Swindon Borough Council Planning Portal, with notable details provided below:

- March/April 2017 – Multiple Parish Councils
- 20th June 2017 / 14th May 2020 – Highways England

2.27 The design of the junction has evolved through discussions with the local highway authority as part of the technical approval and s278 process, including considerations of visibility and highway safety including consideration of opportunities to improve safety and amenity for adjacent properties.

3 User Opportunities

3.1 The proposed site access roundabout will be located on Thornhill Road where there is a PRoW, bridleway and footway for pedestrian, cyclists and horse riders.

3.2 It is to be noted that no part of the PRoW, bridleway or footway are to be altered as a result of the site access works, however there is to be provisions to make connections in the future.

3.3 As mentioned previously, creation of the roundabout will result in a net increase to the safety of pedestrians, cyclists, horse riders and drivers.

Pedestrian

3.4 There is a provision to take pedestrians off carriageway via the Thornhill Roundabout Access leading into the site. The proposed primary street includes a footway linking to a 5m foot/cycle way providing onward connections across to south of the A420 via the Green Bridge .

3.5 At this point in time, a continuous pedestrian connection cannot be provided to the existing bridleway due to the land being owned by a third party to the west of Thornhill Road, however the roundabout includes a pedestrian refuge on the southern arm to facilitate pedestrian connectivity from the footway on the southern side of the primary street towards the bridleway, where a future connection could be made should this land become available.

Cycle

3.6 Cycling routes are designed to provided connectivity across the A420, via the green bridge, and eastwards along Morses Lane.

3.7 The existing bridleway on the west side of Thornhill Road has recently been identified by SBC as a potential strategic cycle route to Swindon Town Centre. Link to the new development is offered by an existing access . A direct link from the proposed new roundabout access is not currently achievable as both the cycleway and adjoining hedgerow are not adopted by SBC and fall outside the applicants' control.

Equestrian

3.8 No dedicated opportunities of improvement for equestrians have been identified. However, improvements to shared use facilities could provide benefit to equestrians where these users are legally permitted.

3.9 At this point in time, a connection cannot be provided to the existing bridleway due to the land being owned by a third party, there is however future potential to create a bridleway connection should this land become available.

4 WCHAR Assessment Team Statement

As Lead Assessor, I confirm that this Walking, Cycling & Horse-Riding Assessment Report has been compiled in accordance with DMRB GG142 and thus contains the appropriate information for the wider design team.

Walking, Cycling & Horse-Riding Lead Assessor

Dean Swann (MCIHT FIHE)

Technical Director

Walking, Cycling & Horse-Riding Assessor

Jaskaran Singh (MSc)

Graduate Consultant

As Design Team Leader, I confirm that the assessment has been undertaken at the appropriate stage of the scheme development and that the wider design team has been involved in the process.

I confirm that in my profession opinion the appointed lead Assessor has the appropriate experience for the role making reference to the expected competencies contained in GG 142.

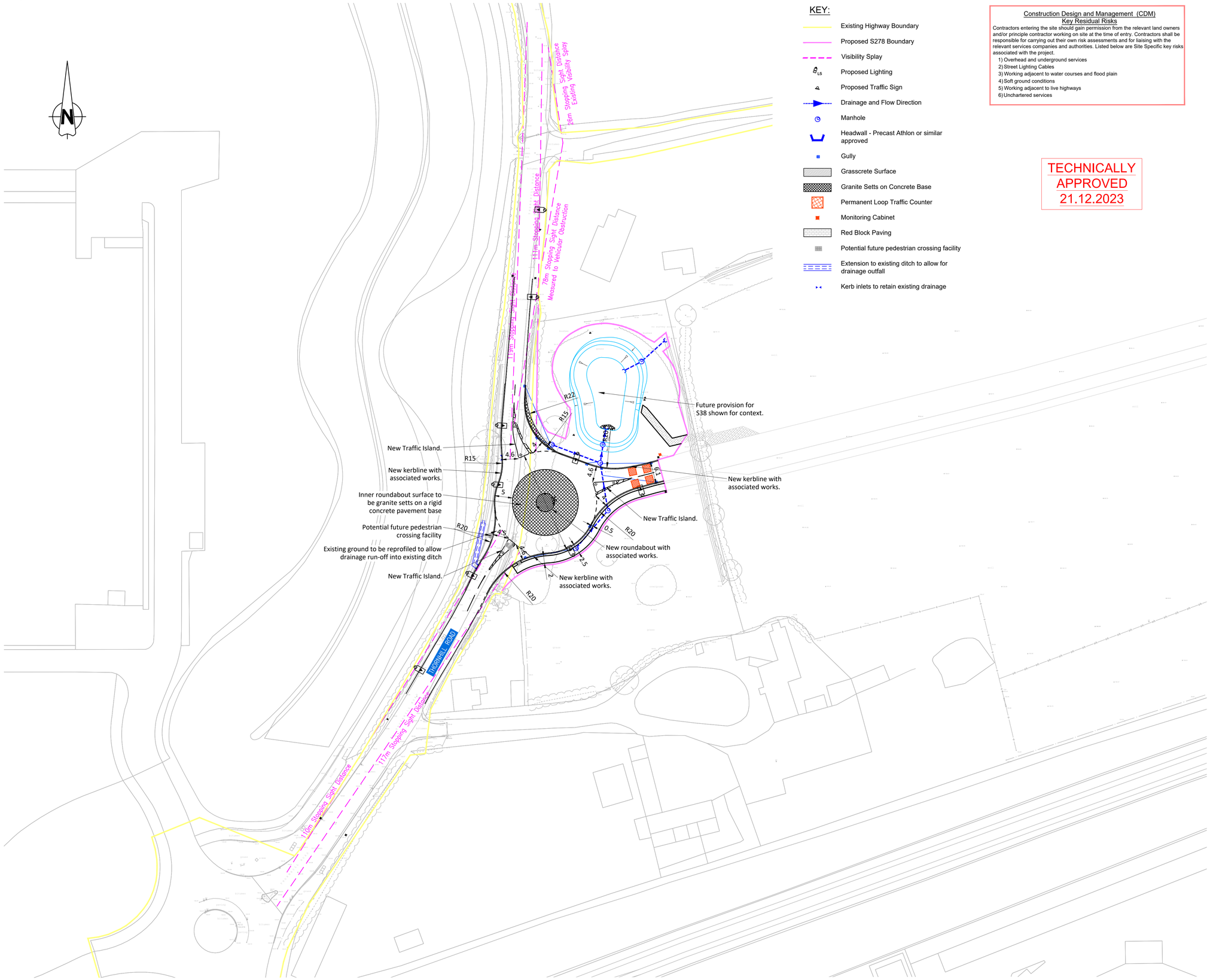
Design Team Leader

Siobhan Murphy (MCHIT)

Associate Director

Appendix A – Thornhill Road Site Access General Arrangement Plan

Original Drawing Size A1



KEY:

- Existing Highway Boundary
- Proposed S278 Boundary
- Visibility Splay
- Proposed Lighting
- Proposed Traffic Sign
- Drainage and Flow Direction
- Manhole
- Headwall - Precast Athlon or similar approved
- Gully
- Grasscrete Surface
- Granite Setts on Concrete Base
- Permanent Loop Traffic Counter
- Monitoring Cabinet
- Red Block Paving
- Potential future pedestrian crossing facility
- Extension to existing ditch to allow for drainage outfall
- Kerb inlets to retain existing drainage

Construction Design and Management (CDM)
Key Residual Risks

Contractors entering the site should gain permission from the relevant land owners and/or principle contractor working on site at the time of entry. Contractors shall be responsible for carrying out their own risk assessments and for liaising with the relevant services companies and authorities. Listed below are Site Specific key risks associated with the project.

1) Overhead and underground services
2) Street Lighting Cables
3) Working adjacent to water courses and flood plain
4) Soft ground conditions
5) Working adjacent to live highways
6) Unchartered services

TECHNICALLY APPROVED
21.12.2023

NOTES:

1. Do not scale from this drawing.
2. All dimensions are in metres unless otherwise stated.
3. Brookbanks consulting ltd has prepared this drawing for the sole use of the client. the drawing may not be relied upon by any other party without the express agreement of the client and Brookbanks consulting ltd. where any data supplied by the client or from other sources has been used, it has been assumed that the information is correct. no responsibility can be accepted by Brookbanks consulting ltd for inaccuracies in the data supplied by any other party. the drawing has been produced based on the assumption that all relevant information has been supplied by those bodies from whom it was requested.
4. No part of this drawing may be copied or duplicated without the express permission of Brookbanks consulting ltd.
5. All dimensions and all levels in metres unless noted otherwise.
6. Any discrepancies noted on site are to be reported to the engineer immediately.
7. Section 278 agreement highway works to carried out in strict accordance with Swindon Borough council's requirements.
8. All works within existing public highway, including any temporary works or traffic management measures, are subject to the approval of Swindon Borough Council. when works are required on the public highway, the contractor shall liaise with and obtain all statutory approvals from Swindon Borough Council, before commencing these works. these approvals include, but are not limited to, approval of traffic management measures, issue of works commencement notices, road opening notices, temporary traffic regulation orders etc.
9. All traffic management shall comply with the requirements as set out in chapter 8 of the traffic signs manual. warning signs may be erected outside the indicated boundaries. any obstructions to traffic or pedestrians shall be properly signed and protected with barriers, cones, signs, and lamps.
10. All planting in visibility splays to be agreed and approved by Swindon Borough Council and in all cases no planting to be above 600mm in height above the carriageway. also no obstructions of any kind within the visibility splay areas.
11. All tactile areas to be laid in accordance with detr "guidance on the use of tactile paving surfaces".
12. All traffic signs and road markings are to be in accordance with the 'Traffic Signs Regulations and General Directions 2016'.
13. Any damage caused to existing footways, roads or other third party property to be made good to the county engineers requirements.
14. Temporary works associated with the construction of the works shall be the responsibility of the contractor.
15. The Highway Agreement's Clerk of Works is to be present during construction and CBR testing for inspections.
16. Permanent loop counter is to monitor the volume and classification of vehicles (Euro 6), whilst also providing the speed of vehicles on approach to the junction. Suitable loop equipment should be provided by a company such as Tagmaster, or similar approved. Monitering equipment is to operate via telemetry with a view to sending regular updates to Swindon Borough Council's Drakewell C2 account upon adoption. Cabinets will need to be solar-powered and a robust maintenance schedule will be required to ensure that the monitoring equipment remains operational.

S	Updated with latest lighting layout	CDW	CM	SM	13.11.23
R	Updated following SBC TA4 comment 24/10/23	CM	CM	SM	03.11.23
Q	Updated following SBC TA3.1 comments 18/10/23	BM	CM	SM	19.10.23
P	Updated following SBC TA3 comment 12/10	CM	CM	SM	18.10.23
N	Updated following SBC TA2 comment 26/09	CDW	CM	SM	06.10.23
M	Drainage updated following comment	CM	CM	SM	20.09.23
L	Amendment to drainage and signs model	CM	CM	SM	23.08.23
K	Pedestrian crossing added to southern side	CM	CM	SM	10.07.23
J	Traffic sensors added to road and note added	CDW	CM	SM	13.01.23
H	Development boundary removed	CDW	CM	SM	05.01.23
G	Updated following RSA comment	CM	SM	SM	20.09.22
F	Updated for SBC submission	CM	SM	SM	01.08.22
E	Design principles added	CM	SM	RM	12.07.22
D	Updated to comments received from SBC June 2022	CDW	SM	RM	01.07.22
C	Footpath North of Roundabout Removed	CM	SM	RM	08.06.22
B	Pedestrian/Cycle route dimensions added	HG	SM	SM	11.03.22
A	Updated S278 Boundary & Drainage Design	CDW	SM	RM	24.02.22
-	First Issue	PS	DS	PAB	30.01.19

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Swindon EDAG

Swindon EDA

Thornhill Road General Arrangement SBC TA S1055 Option 3

Status		Status Date
Approval		JAN' 2019
Drawn	**Checked**	**Date**
PS	DS	30.01.19
Scale	**Number**	**Rev**
1:500	1335/HL/56/100	S

0 10 20 30 40 50
METRES

UNTIL TECHNICAL APPROVAL HAS BEEN OBTAINED FROM THE RELEVANT LOCAL AUTHORITIES, IT SHOULD BE UNDERSTOOD THAT ALL DRAWINGS ARE ISSUED AS PRELIMINARY AND NOT FOR CONSTRUCTION. SHOULD THE CONTRACTOR COMMENCE SITE WORK PRIOR TO APPROVAL BEING GIVEN, IT IS ENTIRELY AT HIS OWN RISK.

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P:\1335\CAD\BCL\Current Drawings\S278-Thornhill Road\1335-HL-056-100S General Arrangement.dwg

Appendix B – Regulating Plan